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From Asia to the United States, Around the World, and Back Again: New Directions in Asian American Immigration History

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Abstract and Keywords

Asian American historians are complicating, broadening, and deepening the history of Asian immigration to the United States and elsewhere. New archival sources, theoretical frameworks, and methodologies have changed the questions historians are asking, where they are doing their research, and the focus of their inquiries. This essay examines some of these new directions. New definitions of migration and migrants and broader chronological and geographical frameworks have expanded the study of Asian American immigration history across time and space. Closer attention to race, ethnicity, class, and gender and sexuality has complicated our understandings of Asian immigrant families, communities, and interethnic and interracial relations. Recent scholarship has focused significantly on recent immigrant and refugee communities, the use of Asian-language sources, and the centrality of transnational, diasporic, and global perspectives. Historians have successfully pushed the boundaries of Asian American immigration history in new ways, contributing to a richer understanding of Asian Americans generally.

Keywords: immigration, migration, refugee, transnationalism, diasporic, global, race, ethnicity, gender

IN 1996, the historian Sucheng Chan proudly proclaimed that Asian American history was “finally coming of age.” Asian Americans had been the subject of articles, books, and studies since the mid-nineteenth century, but these works, mostly written by white missionaries, labor leaders, journalists, and politicians, expressed partisan views in the debate over Asian immigration. In the early twentieth century, Asian Americans became the focus of study by social scientists, but they were viewed as social problems to be solved. It would take the Asian American movement and the “new” social historians of the 1960s and 1970s to fully give voice to Asian Americans, “unearth” their “buried pasts,”

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and document their everyday lives, struggles, and triumphs and their contributions to the making of America.[1]

Today's Asian American historians have built on these pioneering studies to complicate, broaden, and deepen the history of Asian immigration to the United States and elsewhere. New archival sources, theoretical frameworks, and methodologies have changed the questions that historians are asking, where they are doing their research, and the focus of their inquiries. Interdisciplinary influences from sociology, critical race and ethnic studies, gender and sexuality studies, Asian studies, and world history have brought new insights. New definitions of migration and migrants and broader chronological and geographical frameworks have helped expand the study of Asian American immigration history across time and space. Closer attention to race, ethnicity, class, and gender and sexuality has complicated our understandings of Asian immigrant families, communities, and interethnic and interracial relations. And new scholarship (p. 391) has focused on recent immigrant and refugee communities, the use of Asian-language sources, and the centrality of transnational, diasporic, and global perspectives.

The first part of this essay examines recent theoretical and methodological trends in Asian American immigration history. It then analyzes how recent scholarship has shaped our understandings of specific eras of Asian immigration to the United States.

Rethinking Migration

Immigration has traditionally been defined as a push-and-pull process. Conditions in one country, like war, natural disaster, civil unrest, economic instability, and so on "push" desperate peoples out as another country "pulls" them to its shores with better-paying jobs, land, and freedom from persecution. This approach portrays individual immigrants as making free, rational decisions about leaving their homelands. Immigration is a one-way journey to a better life. Immigrants are "uprooted" and then successfully "transplanted" into their new countries of residence, where they readily assimilate into the mainstream.[2]

Since the mid-1980s Asian American and immigration historians have challenged these paradigms to instead focus on the complex factors shaping international migration. Lucie Cheng and Edna Bonacich charted the connections among capitalism, imperialism, uneven economic development, population displacement, and migration abroad in Asia. Yong Chen used Chinese sources to reconsider how Western imperialism and its economic and ideological impact on the Pearl River Delta in China established important preconditions for migration in the nineteenth century. Similarly, scholars studying Filipino migration have clearly placed it within the context of U.S. imperialism and colonialism in the Philippines. Dorothy Fujita-Rony focuses on the "powerful reach of colonialism in Philippine-American relations" and how networks of transpacific trade and militarism as well as American colonial education encouraged Filipino migration to Seattle,

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Washington. Catherine Ceniza Choy uses a “two-shores” approach of archival and ethnographic research in both the United States and the Philippines to locate Filipino nurse migration to the United States within the long history of U.S. colonialism and colonial education in the Philippines.[3]

Asian American immigration historians are also adopting more flexible definitions and frameworks of migration and mobility to refer to the multiple ways in which people move. As Christiane Harzig and Dirk Hoerder explain, migration can be many-directional and multiple, temporary or long-term, voluntary or forced. Migration studies emphasize that men and women on the move have agency. They negotiate their options and constraints and sometimes change directions to keep on the move or return to where they began. This broader framework allows scholars to look at “both ends of mobility,” to examine how migration affects both the sending and receiving societies. Donna Gabaccia has also called on immigration historians to pay more attention to the “continuous, multidirectional, and circular character of migrations” rather than relying (p. 392) upon the older “immigrant paradigm and its well-worn paths of immigration and adaptation to the United States.” Included under the rubric of immigration are peoples who have not followed a unidirectional pattern of movement, whose stay in the United States has been temporary, or whose migration is via nontraditional routes: slaves, indentured laborers, sailors, sojourners, students, visitors, refugees, adoptees, and individuals engaged in serial migrations. Like these migration scholars, the Asian American immigration historian Madeline Hsu has argued for a transnational, “ambulatory” approach that recognizes migrants’ “complicated sets of negotiations, multilayered realities, and multidirectional orientations.” She describes how early twentieth-century Taishanese moved back and forth across the Pacific and often changed their migration strategies and plans along the way. An intention to stay in the United States only temporarily sometimes turned into a lifetime abroad. Triumphant retirements to childhood homes in Taishan were cut short when Chinese Americans returned to the United States out of economic necessity or by choice.[4]

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Diasporic/Global/Transnational Frameworks

Global, transnational, and diasporic frameworks are also becoming increasingly central for the explanation of Asian migration patterns as well as the ongoing social relations and networks that immigrants maintain across geographic, cultural, and political borders. It is no longer possible to think of Asian immigration to the United States as being solely defined by the U.S. nation-state. Instead, scholars seek to explain how Asian immigration to the United States fits within larger global patterns of mobility around the world.[5]

For example, the Chinese and world historian Adam McKeown has illustrated how the "practices and ideologies of migration are embedded in larger global trends and transnational activities." Instead of tracking distinct streams of people moving from one nation to another, he advocates for an approach that centers "mobility and dispersion as a basis from which to begin analysis." His work highlights how both global and local processes shaped Chinese migration, Chinese migrant networks, and international regulation in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Similarly, Eiichiro Azuma has called for a "remapping" of global Japanese migration history that connects Japanese labor migration to the Americas with the history of Japanese colonial expansionism within Asia. Examining the dual influences of both U.S. and Japanese national expansionisms, Azuma's "two-empire" approach emphasizes the role of the Japanese homeland in shaping migrants and their journeys, and it connects the Japanese to the Americas and the Japanese to East and Southeast Asia together into a more complex portrait of the Japanese diaspora prior to World War II.[6]

A key aspect of diasporic and transnational approaches to Asian American immigration is the use of non-English-language sources. Shih-shan Henry Tsai was among (p. 393) the first to use Chinese-language sources to examine the roles of Chinese diplomats and government officials in protecting Chinese citizens abroad and the ways in which Chinese immigrants challenged discriminatory immigration laws in the name of human rights. Alan Moriyama and Yuji Ichioka used Japanese-language sources both to explain how the Japanese government and private emigration companies organized Japanese migration and to demonstrate the complex lives of Japanese immigrants. Madeline Hsu drew from Chinese-language gazetteers to illustrate how Taishanese in the United States maintained transnational ties with their families and villages in Guangdong province and vice versa.[7]

Using Chinese-, English-, and Spanish-language sources, scholars have offered new interpretations of how Asian migrants have lived their lives across national borders in the Americas. McKeown's study of Chinese in Peru, Chicago, and Hawai'i during the early twentieth century documented transnational Chinese migrant social, economic, and cultural connections. Focusing on the U.S.-Mexico borderlands, Robert Chao Romero, Julia Camacho Schiavone, and Grace Peña Delgado have documented how Chinese migrant families and businesses were connected together across national borders, oceans, and continents. They show how the Chinese in Mexico maintained economic and familial ties with their southern Chinese villages, while simultaneously developing

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transnational ties with other Chinese communities in the Americas, notably the United States and Cuba. These took the form of merchant networks, transnational commercial orbits, wholesale trade, contract-labor recruitment, human trafficking, and transnational, interracial families.[8]

Diasporic frameworks have also illustrated how Asian migrants form identities that were often simultaneously tied to their local ethnic communities, their homelands, and communities within diasporas. Collaborative research coming out of the International Nikkei Research Project, for example, documents the long and rich histories of *nikkei*, peoples of Japanese descent, in the Americas as well as the changing patterns and processes of Japanese emigration from the late nineteenth century to the end of the twentieth. Eiichiro Azuma's portrait of Japanese in America also suggests that Japanese migrants were caught between the two empires of the United States and Japan, and, as a result, had conflicted and complex identities, loyalties, and behaviors.[9]

Early twentieth-century Korean and South Asian migrants in the United States practiced diasporic nationalisms that maintained their political connections to their colonized homelands and contributed to larger anticolonial movements. Lili M. Kim has argued that transnational approaches to studying the Korean American experience are "not only useful but necessary," especially during the years of Japanese colonialism in Korea. Because Korean immigrants remained passionately involved in Korean homeland politics, she warns that any failure "to connect the concerns and experiences of Koreans in the United States back to the conditions and realities of Korea would result in inadequate, partial interpretations of Korean immigrant experiences." Richard Kim's study of Korean diasporic nationalism in the early twentieth century illustrates this point even further. Korean immigrants in the United States "saw themselves inextricably linked to their compatriots geographically dispersed across national boundaries (p. 394) and borders," he writes. When Korean immigrants convened the "Korean Congress" in Philadelphia in April 1919 to mobilize support for the Korean independence movement and the new Korean Provisional Government of the Republic of Korea, they saw themselves as part of a larger diasporic movement that represented all Koreans in and outside of Korea.[10]

Under the leadership of charismatic Indian nationalist leaders, South Asians in Canada and the United States became politically active in the cause of Indian independence. The discriminatory treatment they faced in Canada and the United States fed growing anti-British sentiment and mobilized them into nationalist politics. At the same time, they developed a unique ethnic identity as South Asians in North America. Their encounters with white prejudice, anti-Asian riots, disfranchisement, and exclusion bounded them together. Joan Jensen and Seema Sohi have demonstrated that the interconnected movements in Canada and the United States explicitly linked the unequal status of South Asians in North America to the colonized state of their homeland. Nationalists and their activities routinely crossed the U.S.-Canadian border and together were part of a global anticolonial movement in which South Asians challenged laws all over the British empire.[11]

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At the same time that scholars are expanding their perspectives far beyond the borders of the United States, they are also asking new questions about Asian immigration within the broader context of American history, including the making of the modern American state, American national identity, and international relations. Legal historians like Charles McClain, Jr. and Lucy Salyer have analyzed how the Chinese immigrant community's efforts to combat immigration restrictions and housing, employment, and educational discrimination were instrumental in establishing several legal landmarks as well as the national development of immigration laws and procedures. Erika Lee's study of Chinese immigration during the exclusion era showed how the Chinese exclusion laws not only transformed Chinese American lives, immigration patterns, identities, and families but also recast the United States into a "gatekeeping nation." Immigrant identification, border enforcement, surveillance, and deportation policies were extended far beyond any controls that had existed in the United States before. Similarly, Mae Ngai's history of immigration policy traced the origins of the "illegal alien" in American law and society. These included Filipino colonial subjects caught up in the Filipino repatriation program of the 1930s, incarcerated Japanese Americans during World War II, and Chinese American "paper sons" forced to enter the United States with fraudulent documents. Cast as "problems" in U.S. immigration policy, these groups helped shape ideas and practices about race, national identity, citizenship, and state power.[12]

While reconsidering the role of Asian immigration in the broader context of U.S. history, Asian American immigration historians have also examined how Asian American women and gender relations shaped immigration patterns, family and community formations, and work and labor.[13] In addition, controlling the admission of Asian immigrant women and measuring their fitness to enter the country based on gender and sexuality were key components of immigration policies and border control.[14]

(p. 395) New research has continued to document the central roles women have played in changing immigration patterns and community formation. Lili Kim and Ji-yeon Yuh, for example, have written about the central roles that Korean immigrant women and Korean military brides played in sustaining the early Korean immigrant community in the United States and in laying the groundwork for future family-sponsored Korean immigration after 1965. Scholars have also used intersectional analyses of race, gender, and class to explain the dynamics of immigration in the past and present. Catherine Ceniza Choy's study of Filipino nurse migration to the United States illustrates how U.S. colonialism in the Philippines, the racialization of Filipinos, and gendered assumptions about the nursing profession helped to institutionalize the migration of Filipino women for nursing positions in the United States beginning in the early twentieth century.[15]

Utilizing new archival sources and historical methodologies; intersectional analyses of race, class, and gender; and transnational and diasporic frameworks, Asian American immigration historians are asking new questions of Asian immigration to the United States and helping to revise our understandings of U.S. history in general.

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The rest of this article examines the major periods of Asian immigration to the United States and highlights recent scholarship using these new perspectives and sources.

Asians in the Americas

From 1830 to 1930, more than one million Asians entered the United States. Until recently, most studies of Asian immigration largely focused on the period of mass migration and community formation beginning in the late nineteenth century. A common starting point has been the arrival of thousands of Chinese gold seekers in California during the midcentury Gold Rush. Increasingly, however, historians have begun to explore how the roots of Asian American history extend far beyond and before this time period. Gary Okihiro's *Margins and Mainstreams: Asians in American History and Culture* (1994) sought to expand the "canvas of Asian American history" by asking "when and where does the history of Asians in the United States begin?" In tracing how Asians entered into the European historical consciousness through Greek representations of Asia in the fifth century B.C.E., Okihiro makes the point that "Asians did not first come to America; Europeans went to Asia." The resulting European American understandings of Asia as exotic, foreign, and other influenced the European colonization of Asia as well as Europe's search for Asia that ended up in America. "The when and where of Asian American history," Okihiro thus proclaims, "are of an ancient vintage and of a global scale."[16]

A number of scholars inside and outside of the field of Asian American history have contributed to Okihiro's vision to revise the "when and where" starting points of Asian immigration to the United States.[17] One first step in this endeavor has been to connect the history of Asian immigration to the United States to the histories of Asians in the (p. 396) Americas and to world history more generally. Evelyn Hu-DeHart's pioneering scholarship on the Chinese in Mexico and Cuba and her efforts to transnationalize the field of Asian American studies helped to establish a field that can be called "Asians in the Americas."[18] Placing the history of Asian immigration to the United States within the broader history of Asians in the Americas has inspired major reconceptualizations of the Asian American past.

For example, historians have looked back to the history of the Manila galleon trade from 1565 to 1815, during which massive trading ships sailed from Manila and connected Europe, Asia, and the Americas together in a global, transpacific trading network for the first time. The galleons brought an estimated 40,000 to 100,000 Filipinos, Chinese, Japanese, and others from Southeast Asia and India across the Pacific to New Spain (colonial Mexico). As late as 1860, there were more Chinese in Latin America and the Caribbean than there were in North America.[19]

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Scholars like Evelyn Hu-DeHart, Denise Helly, Lisa Yun, and Kathleen Lopez have also turned their attention to the so-called coolie trade, which brought 250,000 Chinese indentured laborers to Cuba and Peru from 1847 to 1874 and another 430,000 South Asians to the British West Indies from 1834 to 1918. Tied to the Black Atlantic world of slavery, the coolie trade helped initiate the transition from slavery to free labor and set the stage for the mass migrations of Asians to the Americas during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. As Moon-ho Jung, Matthew Guterl, and Christine Skwiot have demonstrated, the coolie trade also prompted a global discussion about race and labor across the Atlantic and Pacific oceans and throughout the Caribbean and Latin America. Chinese coolies were both a desirable source of cheap labor and a disruptive social force in the communities in which they lived. These debates over Asian coolies left an indelible mark on the debates over Chinese immigration in the United States and in other white settler societies around the world. In the study of Asian immigration to the United States, historians like John Kuo Wei Tchen have also expanded their inquiries to the East Coast in the early nineteenth century. Together, these works and perspectives help set the stage for a broader understanding of the origins and global roots of Asian immigration to the United States and to the Americas.[20]

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Asian Immigration during the Exclusion Era: 1882 to World War II

With the help of newly discovered sources and different methodological choices, historians have also greatly expanded our understandings of Asian mass migration during the late nineteenth century and early twentieth century and the related exclusion laws that eventually curtailed that migration: the 1875 Page Law and the 1882 Chinese Exclusion Act, which curtailed the immigration of Chinese laborers and women (p. 397) suspected of being prostitutes, but allowed certain "exempt" classes, including merchants, students, teachers, diplomats, and travelers to enter. Later court challenges by Chinese immigrants resulted in allowing the wives and children of merchants and U.S. citizens to enter. Other exclusion laws were the 1907 Gentlemen's Agreement, which barred the immigration of Japanese laborers but allowed family members to apply for admission; the Immigration Act of 1917, which barred all within the newly constructed "Asiatic Barred Zone"; the 1924 Immigration Act, which prohibited the entry of all "aliens ineligible for citizenship," meaning Asians; and the 1935 Tydings-McDuffie Act, which granted the Philippines nominal independence and thereby revoked Filipinos' status as "U.S. nationals" and reclassified them as foreigners subject to the country's immigration and exclusion laws.

Sucheng Chan's edited and coedited volumes on Chinese exclusion laid the foundation for a new generation of scholarship on the history of the Chinese exclusion era. The books that resulted include: George Anthony Peffer's study of Chinese immigrant women and the 1875 Page Law; Lucy Salyer's legal history of the judicial and administrative enforcement of the Chinese exclusion laws; Adam McKeown's examination of Chinese migrant networks in Hawai'i, Peru, and the United States; Madeline Hsu's study of Chinese immigrant transnationalism during the era of exclusion; Erika Lee's book on Chinese immigration during the exclusion era; and Estelle Lau's exploration of Chinese immigrant "paper families."[21]

Comparative works like Mae Ngai's legal history of "illegal immigration," Anna Pegler-Gordon's examination of photography and immigrant documentation, Martha Gardiner's analysis of how immigration and naturalization laws were applied to immigrant women, and Erika Lee and Judy Yung's history of Asian, European, and Mexican immigration through the Angel Island Immigration Station in San Francisco have begun to place Asian immigration and exclusion within the broader context of immigration regulation and comparative racial formation in the United States. Together, these works have demonstrated how immigrants have been both excluded and admitted on the basis of their race, ethnicity, class, gender, sexuality, moral standing, health, and political affiliation, among other factors. These justifications for exclusion and admission often intersected and overlapped with each other to regulate not only foreign immigration, but also domestic race, class, and gender relations within the United States. Moreover, a

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complex state bureaucracy was established to enforce the immigration laws and to exercise the state's control over its geographical borders as well as its internal borders of citizenship and national membership.

Immigrants were profoundly affected by the new laws. But one of the crucial aspects of this new scholarship focuses on how Asian immigration continued in spite of the exclusion laws: Chinese immigrants with fraudulent documents as U.S. citizens, who were paper sons, wives, and daughters; Japanese "picture brides"; Korean laborers, students, and families; South Asian laborers, students, and revolutionaries; and Filipinos who entered as "U.S. nationals." Asian immigrants actively challenged the laws and their discriminatory treatment wherever they could and by any means possible—in the streets, in court, in the barracks of the Angel Island Immigration Station; by writing (p. 398) letters of protest, crossing the border without proper documentation, and telling their stories to future generations to remember.[22]

World War II to 1965

America's emergence as a superpower following World War II forced the country to reconsider its discriminatory immigration policies, and significant transformations in U.S. immigration policy resulted. The first step came in 1943 when Congress repealed the Chinese exclusion acts. By 1946, Congress passed bills to grant quotas of one hundred to India and the Philippines and allowed for the naturalization of immigrants from those countries as well. In 1945 and in 1947, Congress continued to relax the country's immigration laws by passing the so-called War Brides Acts, which allowed the spouses of American servicemen to enter the country.

The repeal of Asian exclusion laws did not open America's doors wide open to Asian immigration, and until recently, the decades between World War II and 1965 have received little scholarly attention. It has been a "historical blind spot," forgotten between the two periods of immigration exclusion and immigration liberalization. Recent scholarship, however, has illustrated how new migrations of military brides, students, refugees, professionals, adoptees, and others during these years laid the foundations for contemporary Asian American communities. Xiaojian Zhao, for example, has demonstrated how these newly arrived Chinese immigrant women and newly reunited Chinese American families played crucial roles in the transformation of Chinese American communities across the nation. Some Filipinos who served in the U.S. military during and after World War II were able to enter the United States under the Selective Service Act as military brides of U.S. servicemen and as professional migrants sponsored by the U.S. government. Between 1946 and 1965, more than 39,000 Filipinos entered the United States.[23]

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Historians examining the Cold War period have also noted how Asian immigration directly followed the growing U.S. hegemony in Asia. The Cold War struggle with the Soviet Union placed a premium on foreign students and professionals within the United States, and new professional and elite Chinese immigrants began to arrive from Taiwan and Hong Kong in the 1950s as part of government-sponsored programs to recruit scientific workers and engineers in the field of military technology. They joined a small group of Chinese students who chose to remain in America after the 1949 revolution. The Cold War–inspired U.S. Exchange Visitor Program also brought small numbers of elite Filipina nurses to the United States to gain skills as well as firsthand knowledge about the United States and its values. These migrants opened the door for the later mass migration of Filipino nurses in the post-1965 period.[24]

Since 1945, the U.S. military presence and dominance in Korea has resulted in ongoing U.S. military troop deployments in South Korea. Relationships between Korean women and U.S. military personnel—sometimes begun in the “camptowns” established (p. 399) near U.S. military bases where prostitution and other illicit businesses were “supported and regulated by the U.S. military for the benefit of its soldiers”—ended in marriage and migration to the United States. Ji-yeon Yuh’s research on Korean military brides places their migration to the United States within the context of the neoimperialist and gendered relationship between South Korea and the United States after 1950. Nearly 100,000 Korean military brides immigrated to the United States between 1950 and 1989.[25]

The migration of transracial, transnational Asian American adoptees also has its roots in the U.S. Cold War relationship with South Korea. Since 1953, the United States has received over 110,000 adopted children from South Korea. New scholarship has demonstrated how transnational Korean adoption became institutionalized as a “national custom” in Korea and as a humanitarian project and an evangelical Christian mission in the United States. An estimated 200,000 Korean children have been transnationally adopted worldwide. Beginning in the 1990s, the United States became a major receiving nation for children adopted from China. Echoing the history of Korean adoption in the United States, the Chinese adoption program provided healthy young infants free of ties to birth families with a “desirable” ethnic background and “flexible” racial status. They soon became known as “model adoptees.” Adoption became understood as a humanitarian act that “rescued” “unwanted” children, as well as a symbol of progress for multicultural America. By 2000, China became the top sending country for international adoption, with more than 5,000 Chinese adoptees arriving that year.[26]

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1965 to the Present

Contemporary Asian America has been largely formed by changes in U.S. immigration policy after 1965 as well as several global factors, including global economic restructuring in both the United States and Asia and increased U.S. political, economic, and military roles in Asia. Scholarship from a wide range of disciplines is filling important historiographical gaps as well as introducing new theoretical frameworks and methodologies for studying Asian American immigration in general.

Motivated by Cold War politics and civil rights activism, the 1965 Immigration and Nationality Act abolished the national origins quotas and created a new set of preference categories based on family reunification and professional skills. Although the 1965 Immigration Act was intended to facilitate emigration from Europe, Asians and Latin Americans have made up the bulk of new arrivals. Since the 1980s, 88 percent of all immigrants came from either of these two geographic regions. Asian immigrants make up around 35 percent of all immigrant admissions. Among the top ten sending countries since 1980 are the Philippines, China/Taiwan, Korea, India, and Vietnam. The majority are family-sponsored migrants or employer-sponsored skilled workers.

Min Zhou and James Gatewood have explained how U.S. investments in developing countries like Asia also resulted in rapid economic growth and high emigration from those countries to the United States. U.S. capital in Asian economies targeted production (p. 400) for export and led to uneven economic development, increased rural-urban migration, underemployment, displaced workers, and the creation of a large pool of potential emigrants. At the same time, the global integration of higher education in many developing countries like India, Korea, the Philippines, and Taiwan resulted in a sizable professional class frustrated with the widening gap between expectations of a higher standard of living and the uneven economic development and lack of mobility opportunities. One result has been “tremendous pressure for emigration.” In the United States, a severe shortage of skilled workers equipped for high-tech industries and services encouraged employer-sponsored skilled migration to the United States. Since the 1980s, Asian immigrant engineers and medical personnel have made up about one-third of the professionals in their industries.[27]

While historical analyses of post-1965 Asian immigration patterns are just emerging, scholars from a broad range of disciplines are offering rich data on these immigrant communities and how they are adjusting in the United States. Like the new histories focusing on earlier Asian migrations, researchers emphasize the importance of global, transnational, and international frameworks in shaping contemporary Asian immigration and the ways in which diasporic Asian identities have been formed.

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Contemporary Chinese Immigration

Most of the new scholarship on contemporary Asian immigration emphasizes how different the new arrivals are from early twentieth-century Asian immigrants. For example, unlike the first generations of mostly working-class male Chinese immigrants who came from China's Pearl River Delta, the new Chinese immigrants, or *san yi man*, come from mainland China, Hong Kong, and Taiwan and include both men and women, members of the working and professional classes, and Cantonese and Mandarin speakers. The difference in numbers is striking as well. In 1960, there were just under 100,000 Chinese-born immigrants in the United States. In 2010, the U.S. Census reported over 3.3 million adult Chinese Americans in the United States. Making up the largest group of Asian Americans and the largest ethnic Chinese population (including Taiwanese) outside Asia, they represent 24 percent of the United States' adult Asian population and in 2015 they became the single largest immigrant group entering the United States.[28]

Some are elite migrants who are part of the "uptown, high-tech Chinese" and are English-speaking scientists, real estate moguls, capitalist entrepreneurs, and professional elites. There are also "downtown, low-tech" Chinese who are low-skilled, blue-collar workers, waiters, domestic workers, cooks, and laundrymen. Some members of the "downtown," "low-tech" Chinese work under exploitative working conditions in crowded garment factories in American cities. Others include those who have entered the country without proper documentation, sometimes with the help of smugglers, or "snakeheads." With neither professional skills nor relatives already in the United States who could sponsor them, an estimated 150,000 Chinese chose to enter (p. 401) without documentation during the 1990s. Their experiences echo many exclusion-era paper sons who also lived in the shadows of society because of their immigration status.

New Chinese immigrants in the United States have helped to revive older Chinatowns in big urban centers like New York City. At the same time, they have also formed new ethnic enclaves in the suburbs, complete with Chinese-owned banks, restaurants, and malls, and Chinese-language newspapers. Monterey Park in Southern California, where Chinese make up more than one-third of the city's population, has been nicknamed "the first suburban Chinatown." Just as with earlier Chinese ethnic enclaves established throughout the Americas beginning in the late nineteenth century, the high concentration of Chinese immigrant-serving businesses and services ease the transition into the United States while fostering close community and homeland ties. Chinese Americans have also successfully integrated into local and national communities. In the United States, the number of elected officials of Asian Pacific American descent almost tripled from 1978 to 2000. In 2012, both the mayors of Oakland, California, and San Francisco were Chinese Americans.

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Just as new Chinese immigrants are adapting to and integrating into their new homes, many also remain transnational migrants simultaneously connected to both their old and new homelands. Some Hong Kong and Taiwanese families are literally spread across the Pacific Ocean between North America and Asia. Choosing to split up the family unit in order to make the most of business opportunities in Asia and educational opportunities for the children in the United States and Canada, “astronaut” Chinese fathers shuttle across the Pacific for business while their wives and children live and attend school in North America. Similarly, Taiwanese “parachute” kids have been left in the United States alone or with caretakers and relatives to go to school and better their chances of gaining admission to a prestigious U.S. university. These transnational “split-family households” are similar to the working-class Chinese immigrants who were also divided from their families during the exclusion era. But unlike these earlier sojourners, who often never saw their families again, today’s elite transnationals are able to travel back and forth much more frequently. New technologies such as email, international phone lines, and the Internet make transnational connections much more frequent, intense, and direct. A number of Chinese immigrants simultaneously express their ethnicity in their adopted homelands and their transnational relationships to their ancestral homelands through flexible and selective citizenship. Globe-trotting Chinese elites with multiple homes and passports exemplify what the anthropologist Aihwa Ong describes as “flexible citizens,” who enjoy privileged access to multiple nations.[29]

Contemporary Filipino Immigration

Scholars of contemporary Filipino migration to the United States emphasize its place within the larger global mass migration of Filipinos around the world. Over eight million Filipinos, around 10 percent of the entire Philippine population, currently work (p. 402) overseas in 140 countries. Made up of nurses, schoolteachers, entertainers, domestic workers, and seafarers working as deck hands, cleaners, mechanics, and cooks aboard container ships and luxury cruise liners, the Filipino diaspora is perhaps the largest in the world.

Filipino immigration to the United States has been shaped by the long-standing colonial and military relationships between the two countries. Many post–World War II migrants were sent to the United States by the U.S. military or through military-based networks. After the 1965 Immigration Act opened up more avenues to immigration, Filipino migration has increased dramatically. Between 1965 and 1985, almost 665,000 Filipinos entered the United States. Between 1990 and 2000, the Filipino population grew by 66 percent. Political conditions in the Philippines, especially the repressive government of Ferdinand Marcos (1965–1985) and the civil unrest caused by communist rebels and Islamic separatists, also spurred migration abroad. Continuing massive unemployment and underemployment as well as income inequality have sustained a culture of migration

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abroad. In 2010, there were 2.55 million Filipinos in the country, making up 18 percent of the adult Asian population in the United States.[30]

The Filipinos who came to the United States in the early twentieth century were largely working-class immigrant laborers. In contrast, since the 1960s, the Philippines has sent the largest number of professional immigrants to the United States. Filipino nurses, doctors, and other medical practitioners have been heavily recruited to the United States to help alleviate a shortage of medical personnel in the country, especially in inner cities and rural areas. Almost 25,000 nurses entered the United States between 1966 and 1985. Another 10,000 arrived between 1989 and 1991. More recently, family-based immigration has brought a greater diversity of Filipino immigrants to the United States as well. Like earlier generations of Filipinos in the United States, contemporary Filipino immigrants continue to maintain strong transnational identities and ties with the Philippines. For example, the Filipino *balikbayan*, permanent residents of the United States, have long been championed as national Filipino heroes for the billions of dollars in remittances that they send to the Philippines each year. More recently, Filipinos' transnational philanthropy has become more organized and direct. As Joyce Mariano has found, there are now thousands of transnational hometown, regional, and national associations, as well as professional and alumni organizations that link Filipino Americans to direct transnational investment and partnership with communities in the Philippines.[31]

Contemporary Korean Immigration

Since 1965, Korean immigration to the United States has skyrocketed. In 1970, the U.S. Census reported 70,598 persons of Korean ancestry in the United States. Twenty years later, the Census counted almost 800,000. This rapid migration occurred (p. 403) within the context of political instability and economic dislocations in South Korea beginning in the 1970s and 1980s. Rapid industrialization and a population explosion resulted in diminished socioeconomic mobility among the middle class, overall income inequality, intense rural-to-urban migration, and increased population density. Koreans—encouraged by the South Korean government—actively engaged in emigration.

Like the earlier wave of Korean immigrants to the United States, the newcomers come intending to stay and migrate as families. A majority have quickly become naturalized citizens. Professionals and students made up the majority of the initial wave of Korean migrants, including physicians, nurses, pharmacists, and dentists. The peak years of Korean immigration were in the late 1970s and 1980s, when many family members of immigrants already in the country began to arrive. Since the 1990s, when South Korea's living standards and democratization have increased, immigration to the United States has declined, but the Korean American population remains vibrant. In 1997, there were almost 136,000 Korean-owned businesses, and in 2010, the Korean population in the United States was estimated to be 1.26 million.

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As in the case of other contemporary Asian migrations, scholars frame Korean immigration to the United States within a larger global framework. The Korean diaspora encompasses Koreans in China, Japan, the former Soviet Union, South America, and the United States formed out of necessity during and after Japanese colonialism and the Korean War. An estimated 5.7 million Koreans live in 160 different countries. Ji-yeon Yuh has focused on this Korean “refuge migration” of military brides, adoptees, labor migrants, political exiles, and international students turned immigrants seeking peace of mind. She finds that Koreans abroad are increasingly developing a diasporic consciousness that “takes the diaspora, not the homeland, as the point of reference.” They seek to create international communities of Koreans outside of Korea that are connected to the Korean diaspora, host countries, and the Korean homeland.[32]

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Contemporary Emigration from South Asia

In the years directly following the passage of the 1965 Immigration Act, emigration from both India and Pakistan—two independent nations created in 1947—increased. The U.S. Census recorded 371,630 South Asians in the country in 1980, including those from India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka. In 1990, the number had almost tripled to 919,626. By 2010, there were over 1.73 million Indian Americans in the United States along with 409,000 Pakistanis and over 147,000 Bangladeshis.[33]

Unlike the small numbers of emigrants who arrived mostly from the Punjab region of what is now India and Pakistan in the early twentieth century, today's newcomers come from throughout India. While the early twentieth-century migration was almost (p. 404) exclusively male laborers, both men and women are contemporary Indian immigrants. The majority are fluent in English and are highly educated professionals, including physicians, engineers, and computer scientists. During the 1960s and 1970s, India's economy could not keep pace with the number of college graduates it produced. Educated professionals sought opportunities abroad just as the Immigration Act offered visas to those with technical skills. Since the 1990s, the rate of Indian immigration has increased as professionals arrive through employment-based immigration programs, and as a growing number of Indian immigrants already in the country sponsor their families to join them. The 2000 Census counted 1.7 million Indian Americans. They were the fastest-growing Asian American group in the 1990s and are highly diverse in terms of language, religion, and, increasingly, class, as more working-class family members arrive to join those already here.

Indian Americans also maintain strong transnational homeland ties, often with the assistance of the Indian government. Beginning in the 1970s, Indians in the United States began to form ethnic organizations and newspapers as part of new community-building efforts. Like their early twentieth-century predecessors, they actively claim an "Indian" identity that is formed at the intersection of India and the United States. In 1999, India began to issue special immigration documents, known as "Persons of Indian Origin Card" that allow "non-resident Indians [NRIs]" to visit India without a visa, own property, buy government bonds, and apply to universities in India. By granting nonnationals the rights of nationals, the Indian government has sought to encourage financial investments and long-term transnational ties between Indians in the diaspora and India. In 2005 alone, India received $27 billion in remittances. As Verne A. Dusenberry and Darshan S. Tatla observe, "NRIs are the new VIPs."[34]

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Southeast Asian Refugee Migrations

Although there was hardly any emigration from Southeast Asia prior to 1975, Southeast Asians now make up a significant proportion of contemporary Asian immigration. The United States' long involvement in Southeast Asia ended in 1975 following the victory of the North Vietnamese communist forces in Vietnam. After the fall of Saigon in April 1975, the United States engaged in emergency evacuations of American military personnel and a small number of South Vietnamese allies. Over the next several months, the total number of evacuees totaled over 130,000. By 1978, the annual admission of Southeast Asian refugees had increased exponentially, most of them admitted under the Indochinese Parole Programs that granted the attorney general ad hoc authority to "parole" into the United States any alien on an emergency basis with no real numerical limit or oversight from Congress. From 1978 to 1980, 267,800 refugees were admitted into the United States. The latter arrivals included second-wave Vietnamese "boat people" who were primarily former political prisoners and ethnic Chinese expelled from Vietnam, as well as a third and fourth wave of (p. 405) Cambodian refugees fleeing the "killing fields" of Cambodia, and Laotian, Mien, and Hmong from Laos who had fought the United States' "secret war" in Laos. Since 1975, around 1.5 million Vietnamese, Lao, and Cambodian refugees have resettled in the United States.

Oral history collections, first-person narratives, and ethnographic studies dominate the field of Southeast Asian American history, and they richly document the refugees' experiences of war, revolution, flight, and resettlement. Booklength historical studies are just beginning to emerge and include Sucheng Chan's study of Cambodian refugees. Based on interviews with community leaders, government officials, resettlement agency workers, and others, *Survivors: Cambodian Refugees in the United States* is the definitive study of how and why Cambodians sought refuge in the United States and how they have fared. Aihwa Ong uses the case of Cambodian refugees to understand "everyday strategies and techniques of citizen-making" in their attempts to cope, navigate, and survive life in the United States. The first generation of Hmong American scholars have been publishing and entering the academy in recent years. Chia Vang's two books on Hmong Americans examine the formation of the Hmong American community in Minnesota, in the United States, and in the diaspora.[35] And Yen Le Espiritu's "critical refugee studies" approach has introduced new frameworks for understanding the importance of U.S. imperialism in creating the refugee subject and the role of memory in preserving Southeast Asian American histories.[36]

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Conclusion

Asian American immigration historians have helped pave the way toward a dramatic rethinking of the Asian American past. We now have a much more diverse and complicated portrait of Asian immigration that follows Asians across the Pacific and back again, as well as throughout the Americas and around the world. Recent scholarship asks how Asian immigration was formative in the making of the United States and American race, class, and gender relations; how it intersected with U.S.-Asian relations; and how it connects to trends in world history and global migration more generally.

In looking toward the future, we need more interdisciplinary exchange to connect historical and contemporary perspectives. This will allow us to examine how earlier patterns set the foundation for the newest migrations; how migration patterns, communities, and identities are similar and different; and how historical methodologies, sources, and frameworks can inform scholarship on the newest Asian immigrants. Similarly, historians should consider how insights from anthropology, sociology, political science, cultural studies, and other fields shed new light on the past. By continuing to draw on the latest interdisciplinary scholarship, historians and others can continue to push the boundaries of Asian American immigration history while also highlighting the historical contexts that frame contemporary phenomena.

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